Strengthening Health Communication Skills in Underserved Vietnamese Medical Trainees and Professionals Through Virtual Medical English Education

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Background

- Medical English proficiency is important for global collaboration, patient communication,
- Medical English is rarely taught in Vietnamese medical school.
- To address this gap, VietMD launched a virtual course led by U.S. physicians.
- The course included bilingual pre-health undergraduate TAs who facilitated breakout sessions and supported cross-cultural communication.

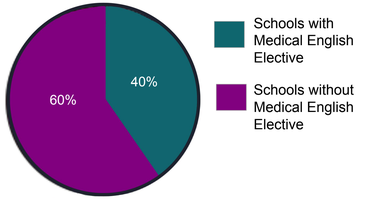

Figure 1. Medical English Course Availability in MD Curricula Across Vietnam. Only 40% of Vietnamese medical schools offer a Medical English elective, while the remaining 60% do not. *Source: MyMBBSAdmission (2023)*

Objectives

- Describe the structure and instructional model of VietMD's virtual Medical English courses.
- Highlight participant diversity across regions and career stages.
- Report self-reported confidence and participant experiences with course components.

Methodology

- Conducted a descriptive study of two virtual Medical English courses (ME201 in 2023, ME202 in 2024)
- Recruited 249 participants through the U.S. Embassy in Vietnam
- Collected pre- and post-course surveys to assess demographics, learning goals, and self-reported confidence
- Analyzed participant responses using descriptive statistics

Results

Table 1. Sample Pre- and Post-Course Survey Questions

Survey Timing	Sample Question	Question Type
Pre-course	How often do you use English for your study or your work?	Multiple choice (frequency)
	What do you want to improve after finishing the course?	Open-ended
	Which do you find more challenging before taking the course?	Multiple choice (e.g., speaking, writing, listening)
	What topics would you like to be covered in more detail in the course?	Open-ended
Post-course	How effective did you find the course's use of technology (e.g., online platforms, communication tools)?	Likert scale (e.g., detractor – promoter)
	After completing the course, how confident do you feel to communicate with English-speaking patients or colleagues?	Group discussion rating (Likert scale)
	Did any technical issues during the course impact your learning experience?	Selected choice: (Yes/No + optional comment)

Table 1. Sample Pre- and Post-Course Survey Questions
Questions assessed English usage, learning goals, confidence, and course experience using multiple formats (e.g., multiple choice, Likert scale, open-ended). This approach supported both quantitative and qualitative evaluation of course impact.

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Table 2. Demographic characteristics of participants in ME201 and ME202

Category	Characteristic	*n*	%
Career Stage	Medical Student	52	25.4%
	Health Professional	149	72.7%
	Other	4	2.0%
Gender	Male	74	35.1%
	Female	132	65.4%
	Prefer not to specify	1	0.5%
Region of Residence	Northern Vietnam	84	40.8%
	Central Vietnam	19	9.2%
	Southern Vietnam	80	38.8%
	Outside Vietnam	23	11.2%
English Certificate	Yes	118	57.6%
	No	85	41.5%
	No response	2	1.0%

Table 2. Demographic characteristics of participants in ME201 and ME202
The majority were health professionals (n = 149) and medical students (n = 52), reflecting VietMD's strong reach to its target audience. Participants came from all regions, with most from Northern (n = 84) and Southern Vietnam (n = 80), showing the program's success in overcoming geographic barriers.

Participant- Reported Confidence Levels in Medical English Communication

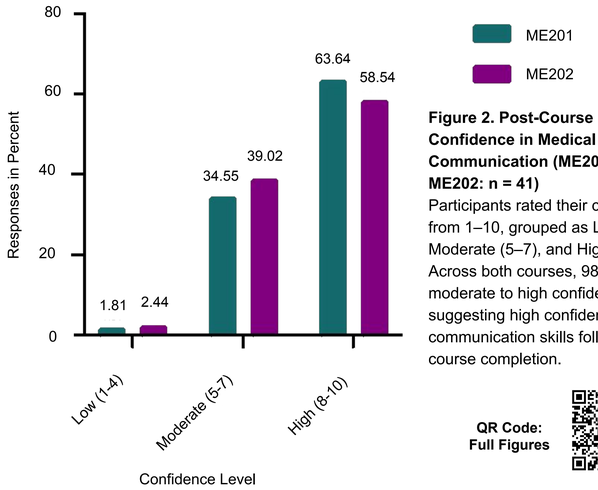

Figure 2. Post-Course Confidence in Medical English Communication (ME201: n = 55, ME202: n = 41)
Participants rated their confidence from 1–10, grouped as Low (1–4), Moderate (5–7), and High (8–10). Across both courses, 98% reported moderate to high confidence, suggesting high confidence in communication skills following course completion.

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Conclusion

- VietMD's virtual Medical English– courses had a positive effect, with 98% of participants reporting moderate to high confidence post-course.
- High confidence among learners, including 41.5% with no prior English certification, show improved access and equity.
- High breakout room ratings highlight the value of interactive, small-group learning for clinical communication.

Future Directions

- Conduct longitudinal studies to assess lasting impact on clinical communication and patient care.
- Expand course offerings to include other healthcare professionals, such as nurses and allied health workers.
- Refine curriculum using participant feedback to improve relevance and engagement.

Acknowledgements

- VietMD, Wynn Medical Center Research and Education Institute, and the U.S. Embassy in Vietnam for their support
- Nhi Truong, MS, for her mentorship, encouragement, and guidance throughout the research process
- Dr. Huynh Wynn Tran for his leadership and vision in expanding access to Medical English education

By combining physician-led instruction with support from bilingual pre-health students, this program demonstrates a sustainable path for expanding Medical English access.